Ukraine: EU support at risk from 2028

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EU, Ukraine—EU support for Ukraine at risk from 2028

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Marine Le Pen's likely victory in France’s presidential election and her pledge to end all financial aid to Kyiv within six months could prompt a broader unraveling of EU support, which would be much more consequential for Ukraine than the loss of US support.
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Once financial support becomes a national rather than EU commitment, fiscally stretched and skeptical governments would likely follow France’s lead, blowing a hole in Ukraine’s finances beyond 2028.
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Le Pen and like-minded leaders would also use their vetoes to block further sanctions on Russia and Ukraine’s EU accession, weakening Kyiv's position just as incentives to negotiate an end to the conflict with Russia are increasing.

A president Le Pen would suspend bilateral and EU aid for Ukraine from 2028. Le Pen's Ukraine policy is now driven by fiscal politics at home rather than her historically pro-Russian stance. Her plan to cut aid six months after taking office suggests she would not touch money already agreed but would block any new bilateral and EU funding from 2028.

Le Pen would have several ways to block EU funding. The most powerful tool would be her veto of the EU's next seven-year budget and its proposed €100 billion facility for Ukraine. As we have previously said, Le Pen could achieve this by withholding France's contribution to the EU budget, to advance her broader EU priorities and ensure that any deal she oversees does not require an increase in France’s annual €26 billion contribution to Brussels (see: Le Pen's €180 billion bid for fiscal credibility falls flat , 7 October 2026). Le Pen’s National Rally party also opposes the use of Russia’s immobilized assets in Euroclear.

Other countries would follow France’s lead. If France stalls EU-wide efforts, Ukraine aid would become bilateral. France’s actions would give countries further from the front line an excuse to curb their contributions. For Italy, Spain, Greece, Austria, Hungary, Slovakia and others, Ukraine is not a priority. Indeed, Italian support is already likely to falter after next year’s election if prime minister Giorgia Meloni is forced into a more right-leaning coalition with Roberto Vannacci’s National Future party (see: Meloni faces tight re-election odds , 8 September 2026). The bilateralization of aid would likely result in a situation where only northwestern Europe continues to fund Ukraine, but these countries would be unlikely to fully offset the losses of contributions from many member states in core, southern, and

central Europe.

Beyond funding, Le Pen's veto would affect Ukraine accession plans and Russian sanctions. Accession would become almost impossible, since it needs unanimity at every step and Le Pen has already expressed opposition to membership. On this issue, Le Pen would not be alone, as a majority of member states are opposed to Kyiv’s admittance, despite their public pledges of support.

EU capitals have four main concerns about admitting Ukraine: weak rule of law, migration, reduced access to EU funds, and how to handle the Russian-occupied territories.

The loss of aid and the prospect of membership would remove the EU's most valuable long-term offer to Kyiv. Alongside security guarantees, EU funds and membership were important incentives offered to Ukraine to accept a difficult deal in last year’s peace talks; a later US proposal reportedly envisaged accession as early as January 2027. Without that carrot, Zelensky would find it much harder to sell painful concessions at home once negotiations reach a serious stage.

Sanctions would be similarly vulnerable. Le Pen has called for lifting EU sanctions on Russia since at least 2017. The EU's economic sanctions come up for renewal in July 2027, and a French veto would end them. She could also let sanctions on individuals lapse when they come up for renewal and veto new sanction packages.

Losing France as a staunch supporter could also break Europe's united front in negotiations. Europe’s leverage in peace talks rests on aid, Russia’s frozen assets, security guarantees, sanctions relief and EU membership. When Washington pressed Kyiv to accept its 28-point plan last November, European powers produced a counterproposal within days and pushed back on the terms that largely favored Moscow.

Le Pen’s veto would, however, strip the EU of much of that leverage. Officials in her party say Le Pen would back a common EU position and not press Kyiv to recognize Russian gains. It is unclear whether she would hold that line if offered a chance to end the war and restore economic ties with Moscow.

The US is very unlikely to step in if the EU falters; our basecase remains that the US will keep defensive aid flowing but offer Kyiv little else (see: Diplomatic fallout with Ukraine will persist beyond intelligence-sharing resumption , 23 October 2026).

Managing a likely Le Pen presidency will become one of Ukraine’s central foreign policy challenges. With more urgent challenges and an uncertain winter ahead, President Volodymyr Zelensky’s administration has not yet settled on a strategy. Its likely approach would be to court Le Pen diplomatically, emphasizing France’s current and potential future defense-industrial and business ties with Ukraine. That approach may prove ineffective, as Le Pen’s domestic fiscal agenda requires her to reduce spending abroad (see— France: Le Pen will aim to address market fears , 2 October 2026).

Happy to discuss,

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